



Before the fast-track: Like Sachin Tendulkar (in pic), Vaibhav Suryavanshi (below) has started stitching together early scores that have turned hype into promise.

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players. You are only competing within your own age group. But once you reach the senior level, the variety and level change. It becomes like an ocean of talent. There are limited spots also, and so many players vying to grab it," he said. "You cannot compromise on your work ethic. When you become famous, you get distracted. What affects your performance is your work ethic. When cricket is your priority, you have to work hard for it. He [Mhatre] does it," Shetty added.

International cricket is the destination, but it is not the only measure of success. Players from the 2022 and 2024 editions of the World Cup have continued to show their capabilities with their State sides, but are yet to get their chance with the Indian national team.

"I always judge the U-19 and India-A programme on how many of these boys are quickly able to assimilate into the Ranji Trophy, which will then give them the platform to play for India. It's not

how many from your batch played for India and how quickly," former National Cricket Academy director Rahul Dravid had said in an earlier interview. "When I hear of a guy who is not well recognised but is the captain of his State team, I think 'Wow, we've done something'. It is not an easy space to grow up, to discover yourself as a cricketer, with everything being watched and everything being analysed," he had added.

For decades, the Indian game has sold a simple tradition: that talent is best tempered in the domestic grind, first in Ranji Trophy whites and then, if the runs or wickets keep coming, in India colours. Even the

ones fast-tracked were rarely untested. Sachin Tendulkar scored a First-Class century (100) on his Ranji Trophy debut for Bombay in 1988, before he made his India debut later that year. Virat Kohli's rise was rapid, but it still ran through Ranji returns.

The U-19 World Cup can compress a player's reputation into three weeks and inflate it into something larger than the player.

For every Kohli who uses it as a springboard, there are others who find the next step is not a step at all. Ravikant Singh (2012) played just one First-Class match (46 runs, no wickets). Vijay Zol (2012, 2014) went on to feature in 15 First-Class games, scoring 733 runs at 34.90. Karan Kaila (2014) played nine, taking 22 wickets and scoring 348 runs. Ajitesh Argal (2008), Man of the Match in the final, finished with 10 First-Class matches and 24 wickets. They were once framed as the future, only to learn that senior cricket does not care for promise, only proof.

The next challenge now is managing workload, expectations, and the slow, unglamorous business of making a teenager into a professional. The title will act as a launchpad, not a guarantee. The few who handle that transition will be the ones who last.

